did Kennedy not mention the missiles when he met with Gromyko on October 18? “Because no such facts exist,” asserted Zorin, answering his own question. “The Government of the United States has no such fact in its hands except this falsified information of the United States Intelligence Agency, which are being displayed for review in the corridors and vestibules of the UN and which are sent to the press. Falsity is what the United States has in its hands, false evidence.”[20]

Stevenson decided to fight back. “I want to say to you, Mr. Zorin, that I do not have your talent for obfuscation, for distortion, for confusing language, and for doubletalk,” he began. “And I must confess to you that I am glad that I do not!” After suggesting that Zorin was flip-flopping on the issue of whether there were any Soviet weapons in Cuba and whether they were offensive or defensive, he continued: “All right, sir, let me ask you one simple question: Do you, Ambassador Zorin, deny that the U.S.S.R. has placed and is placing medium- and intermediate-range missiles and sites in Cuba? Yes or no—don’t wait for the translation—yes or no?” Zorin responded, after waiting for the translation: “I am not in an American court of law, and therefore do not answer a question put to me in the manner of a prosecuting counsel … you will have your answer in due course.”

Stevenson pressed on: “You can answer yes or no. You have denied they exist. I want to know if I understood you correctly. I am prepared to wait for my answer until hell freezes over, if that’s your decision. And I am also prepared to present the evidence in this room.” Stevenson’s aides brought enlarged photographs of Soviet missile sites under construction taken by U-2 pilots in the vicinity of San Cristóbal. There were photographs taken in August, when no construction could be observed, and ones taken a week and a few days prior to the presentation, demonstrating the dramatic change in the landscape and the appearance of tents and missile installations where there had been none before. Stevenson’s performance impressed President Kennedy, who remarked, watching the exchange on television, “Terrific. I never knew Adlai had it in him.”[21]

The next day the *New York Times* came out with a huge front-page photo of Stevenson presenting his evidence, making the showdown at the United Nations the day’s top story. It would appear that Khrushchev was never informed about the public relations fiasco at the UN. Zorin tried to